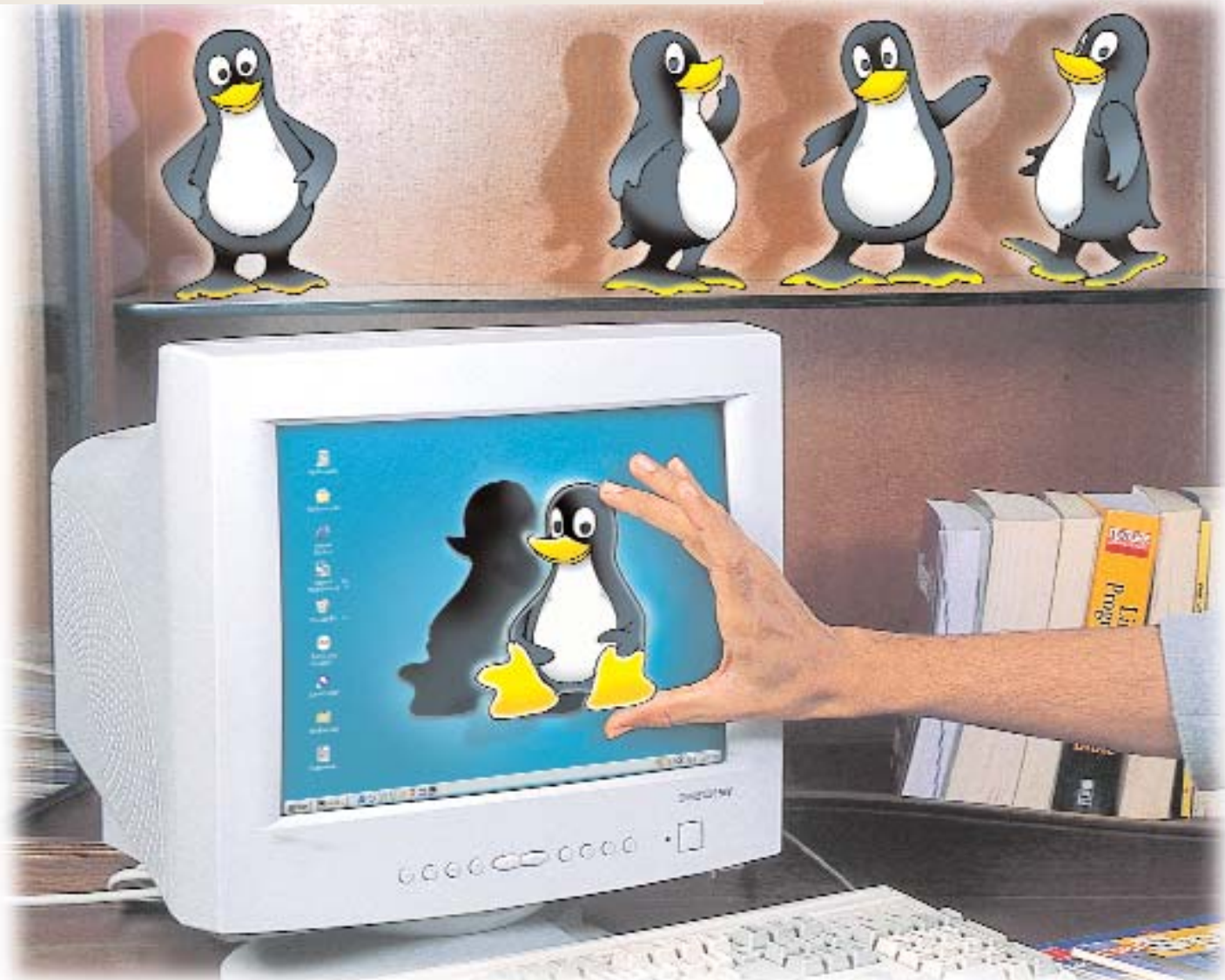


IN TEST: **7** LINUX DISTRIBUTIONS



Photograph: Jiten Gandhi, Imaging: Mahesh Benkar

Your flavour of **LINUX**

Considering using Linux, but can't decide which distribution is your best bet? Let our Test Centre help you make the decision

ROSSI FERNANDES

Do you get the creeps each time you hear the name Linux? The installation is tough, it's difficult to use—that's the Linux lore you must have heard. But take heart, the bad days have gone and Linux is gradually moving into the home user market.

There are firms such as Dell that are actually selling PCs with Linux preinstalled on them. Linux was a little difficult to use some years back due to the absence of a graphical interface installation and a not-so-easy partitioning process where you could go wrong and delete some Windows partition and lose data. But the picture is different with the introduction of graphical

installation methods adopted by distributions such as RedHat.

Distributions are packages that use the open source Linux kernel and give you a lot of software bundled along with the main Linux operating system itself. This also means installation methods, customisation and hardware support that may have been added by the company that has made the distribution.

Latest updates are important factors as they contain better hardware support, with bugs fixed. More significantly, Linux is open source. But why should you go for a distribution from the market when you can simply download a whole CD or two from the Net with most of the